

TEACHING STATEMENT

Danny Turkson (dturkson@unc.edu)

My first formal teaching experience was in Ghana, where as a teaching assistant at the University of Ghana I led weekly tutorials in econometrics and applied statistics for classes of 150 to 250 undergraduates, and ran separate sessions for roughly 30 graduate students in an MA Economic Policy Management program. Teaching in that setting (large, under-resourced classrooms, students arriving with widely varying preparation, many of them the first in their families to pursue university education) taught me something I have carried into every classroom since: that the instructor's job is not to deliver content but to make contact. A student who does not feel seen, or who believes the material is not meant for them, will not learn regardless of how clearly the material is presented. I have been teaching continuously since 2015, across three institutions and two countries, and that conviction has only deepened.

Teaching Philosophy

My teaching is organized around three principles that I have arrived at through practice and through formal training in pedagogy: specifically a two-semester course in Teaching Methods in Economics at UNC-Chapel Hill and earning a Teaching Associate Certificate at UNC-Greensboro.

Economics as a lens, not a set of procedures. My primary goal is for students to leave my course thinking differently about the world around them, not merely having memorized a toolkit. In introductory economics, I anchor every major concept in a concrete, policy-relevant example. When teaching comparative advantage, I ask students how they and their roommates divide household tasks, and what that implies about trade. When teaching externalities, I connect it to pollution debates students have seen in the news. When teaching labor markets, I use examples drawn directly from my own research on employment, welfare, and family structure. Students consistently note in evaluations that I “connected it to real life events” and that I helped them understand “the logic” behind answers rather than just the mechanics. This is deliberate because I want students to encounter an economic question in the real world; in a news story, a policy debate, or their own lives; and feel equipped to think it through.

Multiple pathways to understanding. Students in my courses have different learning styles, different levels of prior preparation, and different constraints on their time outside class. I design courses to meet them across that variation. In every class I have taught at UNC-Chapel Hill, I have used a layered approach: interactive in-class polls (Poll Everywhere) that check understanding in real time and allow every student to respond without fear of judgment; collaborative recitation sessions where students work through problems in groups before I debrief; recorded lectures posted to Canvas so students who miss class or need to review can do so on their own schedule; annotated slides posted after each lecture; chapter-level multiple choice banks for self-testing; and consistent, accessible office hours, including virtual options. Students have told me that having “a multitude of resources to study from depending on our own learning style” is one of the most valued features of my courses, and that it ensures gaps in understanding are “certainly not due to a lack of resources.” I have also learned from feedback. My Fall 2023 evaluations signaled that some students wanted more real-world engagement and stronger pacing. I took that seriously, and my Summer 2025 evaluations (my strongest across nearly every dimension, with a mean of 4.59 on overall learning and 4.63 on intellectual challenge) reflect the changes I made in response.

Respect and belonging as preconditions for learning. Across all five semesters I have taught at UNC-Chapel Hill, my highest-rated dimension has been “the instructor treated all students with respect,” with scores ranging from 4.48 to 4.82 out of 5. I do not treat this as a nice-to-have. Students who do not feel respected do not take intellectual risks, do not ask questions when confused, and disengage quietly rather than visibly. I am especially attentive to students who are the first in their families to attend university, students from underrepresented backgrounds, and international students navigating a new academic culture – because I was that student. I grew up in Ghana, completed my undergraduate and master's degrees at the University of Ghana, and arrived in the United States for doctoral study without

the informal knowledge of how American universities work that many domestic students take for granted. That experience makes me deliberate about signaling availability: I hold regular office hours, respond promptly to emails, stay after class for questions, and reach out proactively to students who seem to be struggling. One student wrote that I “helped them become more confident with this course through study strategies”; another noted that I genuinely wanted to understand the angle from which they were approaching a problem, not just correct the answer. That kind of individualized engagement is something I treat as central to teaching, not as an add-on to lectures.

Teaching Experience

My teaching portfolio spans a decade and covers both undergraduate and graduate instruction. At the University of Ghana, I taught tutorials in econometrics, applied statistics, applied mathematics, and microeconomics across undergraduate and graduate levels, including weekly STATA training sessions for final-year undergraduates preparing to conduct independent research. At UNC-Greensboro, I supported courses in principles of microeconomics (delivered entirely via Zoom during the COVID-19 pandemic), an experience that pushed me to develop virtual engagement strategies that I have continued to draw on, including recorded lectures, virtual office hours, and online collaborative tools. At UNC-Chapel Hill, I have been the sole instructor of record for ECON101 Introduction to Economics five times (Summer 2023, Fall 2023, Summer 2024, Summer 2025, and Summer 2026) with average enrollment of approximately 30 students per section, and have served as a teaching assistant for Econometrics, Analysis of Public Finance, and Intermediate Microeconomics. Across these roles I have designed syllabi, written and graded exams, led recitations, and supervised student learning from first principles through intermediate theory.

Courses I Am Prepared to Teach

At the **undergraduate level**, I am prepared to teach core courses in Principles of Microeconomics, Principles of Macroeconomics, Intermediate Microeconomics, Labor Economics, Health Economics, Development Economics, Public Finance, and Econometrics. My research and teaching backgrounds make me particularly well suited to courses that connect economic theory to policy, inequality, and human capital: courses where students benefit from seeing that the methods they are learning have direct bearing on questions that matter.

At the **graduate level**, I can teach courses in econometrics, applied microeconomics, labor and family economics, and health and development economics. I would also be eager to develop new courses drawing directly on my research, including a graduate seminar in *Family Economics and Intergenerational Inequality* – covering dynamic models of household behavior, child development, and the intergenerational transmission of disadvantage – and an applied course in *Causal Inference and Policy Evaluation* that trains students in the full toolkit of modern identification strategies, from quasi-experimental methods, using policy-relevant datasets from the United States and Sub-Saharan Africa.

Looking Forward

Teaching and research are, for me, genuinely continuous activities. The questions I bring into the classroom (how do families make decisions under constraints? how do early-life environments shape long-run outcomes? how do we identify causal effects when behavior is endogenous?) are the same questions that motivate my research. I want my students to leave not only with technical tools but with the habit of asking those questions themselves. The students at the center of my research agenda – some children born into fragile families, households navigating limited resources, workers in constrained labor markets – are often the same students sitting in my classroom, or students whose families and communities are directly affected by the policies we study. That overlap is not incidental. It is, for me, one of the most compelling reasons to keep teaching well.